The Five Questions Solution

Student-First Used Products Marketplace

Based on the investor assessment and pitch document for a student-first used products marketplace. The solution turns the business idea into a clear product plan before writing code.

Core answer:

Build a focused campus marketplace MVP that proves demand, trust, and repeat use before expanding. Start with textbook resale and student essentials, then add secure payments, delivery partnerships, and university/community integrations.

Source basis

The source document identifies a strong opportunity around a trusted student economy: verified users, safer payments, ratings, campus-based discovery, and recurring demand every semester. It also warns that the idea is too broad if launched globally first, and recommends starting with one campus or one student-heavy city.

1. PHASES - What is the MVP? What comes after? What is the long-term vision?

The product should be built in phases. The goal is not to build a full global marketplace first. The goal is to validate one trusted student marketplace in one focused area.

Phase	Goal	Features / Output	Success Measurement
Phase 1: MVP	Prove that students will buy and sell safely in one campus or student city.	Register/login, student verification, create listing, image upload, categories, search, buyer-seller chat, ratings, reporting unsafe listings, basic admin dashboard.	500 student users, 100 active listings, 50 completed transactions, positive feedback on trust and ease of use.
Phase 2: Trust and growth	Improve safety, repeat use, and marketplace density.	Better moderation, seller badges, saved searches, notifications, dispute flow, improved reviews, campus filters, seasonal textbook campaigns.	More repeat users, lower scam reports, faster item sales, more listings before semester start.
Phase 3: Monetization	Start earning revenue without hurting early adoption.	Transaction fee, featured listings, safe payment/escrow fee, premium seller tools, local ads, delivery partnerships.	Revenue per transaction, conversion from free to paid features, healthy transaction volume.
Phase 4: Expansion	Move from one campus to many campuses.	Student ambassador program, student union partnerships, university sustainability partnerships, local business partnerships.	Successful launches in multiple campuses with repeatable onboarding playbook.
Long-term vision	Become the trusted marketplace for the student economy.	Campus-to-campus second-hand platform for textbooks, furniture, electronics, appliances, dorm items, and local student services.	Recognized student-first marketplace with strong trust, affordability, and sustainability position.

Decision: The MVP is not eBay for everyone. The MVP is a trusted student marketplace for one campus or one student-heavy city.

2. USER FLOW - What does the user actually do from landing to first success?

There are two main user types: buyer and seller. The first success must happen quickly: a seller posts a useful item, and a buyer finds it, contacts the seller, and completes a safe purchase.

Step	Buyer Flow	Seller Flow
1	Lands on homepage and sees student-focused categories such as textbooks, furniture, electronics, and dorm items.	Lands on homepage and sees a clear message: sell student items quickly to nearby students.
2	Searches by campus, category, price, condition, and seller rating.	Creates an account and verifies student identity.
3	Opens a listing with images, price, description, condition, location, and seller rating.	Creates a listing with title, category, description, price, condition, campus/location, and images.
4	Registers/logs in before messaging or buying.	Receives buyer message in safe chat.
5	Chats with seller, asks questions, agrees pickup or delivery.	Confirms price, pickup/delivery plan, and transaction method.
6	Completes purchase using safe payment or agreed pickup flow.	Marks item as sold and receives payment or confirmation.
7	Leaves rating and review after the transaction.	Receives rating and builds trust for future sales.

First success definition: A student lists or buys one useful item safely inside the campus community.

3. DATA FLOW - What data is created, stored, moved, or transformed?

The marketplace creates and moves data around users, listings, images, search, messages, payments, reviews, and moderation. Trust and safety data is not optional - it is part of the core product.

Data	Created By	Stored In	Used For
User account	Buyer or seller during registration.	Users table/collection.	Login, profile, role, account status.
Student verification	User uploads/verifies student email or campus proof.	Verification records.	Trust, campus access, verified badge.
Product listing	Seller creates item.	Listings table/collection.	Marketplace search, category browsing, sale status.
Product images	Seller uploads images.	Object/blob storage plus image URLs in database.	Listing display and buyer confidence.
Search/filter activity	Buyer browsing behavior.	Search index/logs where appropriate.	Better discovery, ranking, category insights.
Chat messages	Buyer and seller conversation.	Messages table/collection.	Safe communication and transaction coordination.
Transaction/payment	Buyer starts purchase, seller accepts.	Orders/transactions database plus payment provider records.	Order status, fees, escrow/safe payment, receipts.
Ratings/reviews	Buyer and seller after transaction.	Reviews table/collection.	Trust score and marketplace quality.
Reports/moderation	Users report unsafe listing or behavior.	Reports table/collection and admin notes.	Remove scams, protect students, improve safety.

4. ARCHITECTURE - What are the components? How do they connect?

A simple, scalable architecture is enough for the MVP. The architecture should support a web/mobile frontend, backend API, database, file storage, search, notifications, payments, and admin tools.

Component	Responsibility	Connects To
Frontend web app	Homepage, browsing, listing pages, register/login, seller listing form, chat UI, admin UI.	Backend API.
Backend API	Business logic for users, listings, chat, reviews, reports, transactions, and permissions.	Database, storage, search, payments, notifications.
Authentication service	Login, registration, roles, JWT/session, student verification status.	Backend API and user database.
Database	Stores users, listings, messages, orders, reviews, reports, admin data.	Backend API.
Image/object storage	Stores uploaded product images safely and cheaply.	Backend API and frontend via secure URLs.
Search service	Enables fast search by category, campus, price, condition, keyword, and rating.	Backend API and listings database/index.
Payment provider	Handles card/mobile payments, escrow/safe-payment logic where available, receipts, transaction status.	Backend API and transaction records.
Notification service	Sends email/push notifications for messages, offers, sold items, reports, and admin actions.	Backend API.
Admin dashboard	Moderation, reported listings, user issues, verification review, marketplace metrics.	Backend API and database.

Architecture flow: User opens frontend -> frontend calls backend API -> backend reads/writes database -> images go to object storage -> search index updates -> payment provider confirms transaction -> notifications inform buyer/seller -> admin dashboard monitors trust and safety.

Recommended MVP architecture diagram

Frontend Web App / Mobile Web -> Backend API -> Database

Backend API -> Object Storage for product images

Backend API -> Payment Provider for safe payment

Backend API -> Notification Service for email/push alerts

Backend API -> Search Index for fast product discovery

Admin Dashboard -> Backend API -> Reports, users, listings, and transactions

5. STACK RATIONALE - Why this framework, database, and AI model?

The stack should match the MVP: fast to build, secure enough for real users, simple to operate, and scalable later. Do not choose technology only because it is popular. Choose it because it supports the business goal.

Layer	Recommended Choice	Why This Choice	Why Not Something Else First
Frontend	Next.js or React	Fast marketplace UI, reusable components, good SEO for listings, strong developer ecosystem.	A native mobile app is slower and more expensive for MVP. Start with responsive web first.
Backend	ASP.NET Core Web API or Node.js/NestJS	Both are good for APIs, authentication, transactions, and scaling. ASP.NET Core is excellent if the team is strong in C#.	Avoid microservices at MVP stage. A clean modular monolith is simpler and cheaper.

Layer	Recommended Choice	Why This Choice	Why Not Something Else First
Database	PostgreSQL	Strong relational model for users, listings, orders, reviews, reports, and transactions. Reliable and affordable.	NoSQL can work, but relational data integrity is useful for marketplace transactions and trust data.
Images	Cloud object storage such as Azure Blob Storage, AWS S3, or Cloudinary	Cheap, scalable, and designed for product images.	Do not store images directly in the main database.
Search	PostgreSQL full-text search first; Algolia/Meilisearch later	Good enough for MVP and cheaper to start. Upgrade when listings grow.	Advanced search tools are useful later but may be unnecessary cost early.
Payments	Stripe or local trusted payment provider	Reduces security risk and supports payment flows, receipts, and transaction records.	Do not build custom payment handling from scratch.
AI	No core AI model needed for MVP. Add AI later for moderation, image/category suggestions, scam detection, and listing text improvement.	Trust, supply, demand, and transactions matter more than AI in the first version.	Do not add AI just to look modern. Add it only when it improves safety or listing quality.

Final Build Checklist Before Coding

- Define the first launch market: one campus or one student-heavy city.
- Choose the first category focus: textbooks first, then furniture and electronics.
- Interview 10-30 students before building too much.
- Write the buyer and seller user stories.
- Design the database entities: User, Verification, Listing, Image, Message, Transaction, Review, Report.
- Define trust and safety rules: verification, reporting, moderation, banned items, payment safety.
- Choose the MVP stack and avoid unnecessary microservices.
- Define success metrics: users, active listings, completed transactions, repeat users, trust feedback.
- Prepare the launch plan: student ambassadors, campus groups, social media, student unions.
- Only then start coding the MVP.

Sensei Note

If you cannot explain the phases, user flow, data flow, architecture, and stack rationale, you do not yet know what you are building. For this student marketplace, the answer is clear: start focused, prove trust, prove demand, and expand only after students successfully trade with each other.

Best one-liner

We are building the trusted student marketplace where students can safely buy and sell used textbooks, furniture, electronics, and campus essentials - starting campus by campus.